

NEONNOIRE

Written by
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THE LOOK

Tokyo as a memory that is still happening.

The city in this film belongs to no single year. Pay phones beside smartphones. Boxy CRT televisions glowing in shop windows. Showa-era vending machines humming on empty corners beneath new glass towers. None of it is ever commented on. It is simply how the world is.

LIGHT. The city lights the characters, not the sky: vending machines, shop signs, train windows, fluorescent tubes. Sodium orange against a sick fluorescent green. Soft halation around every light, blacks slightly crushed. It should look like film, and feel like something remembered.

RAIN. Never glamorous. No lightning, no storms. Cold, steady, patient rain that turns the streets black and reflective.

CAMERA. Wide and patient. Close-ups are rare, so they count. We watch people inside the city, not apart from it.

SOUND. Real Tokyo sounds, placed slightly wrong: a crossing melody for an empty street, a television laughing in an empty room. Music arrives late, and sparingly.

OTHER LIVES. There is always a sign of other people -- a lit window, a radio through a wall, laundry overhead. Every private moment happens among thousands of others.

NOTHING IS EXPLAINED.

LANGUAGE. The Voss sisters speak English to each other. Dialogue marked (in Japanese) is spoken in Japanese and subtitled in English.

REFERENCE POINTS. Ozu's TOKYO STORY for restraint. KOWLOON GENERIC ROMANCE and the 1997 illustrated Kowloon Walled City panoramas for density, texture and memory.

FADE IN:

1 EXT. BACKSTREET, KANDA - NIGHT

1

Rain. Not a storm. Just cold, steady, patient rain.

A narrow street of shuttered shops that could belong to any year of the last forty. Hand-painted signs. Tangled wires overhead. At the corner, an old vending machine throws cold white light across the wet asphalt, rain falling through it in columns.

Its HUM is the loudest thing here.

MARA VOSS (24), American, walks fast, arms folded, no umbrella. Hair soaked flat, held back by a cheap enamel clip shaped like a small red bird. She has been crying, or she is about to.

Her phone BUZZES. The screen: VERA.

She looks at it. Lets it ring. Declines.

It buzzes again at once. VERA.

MARA
(to the phone)
Not tonight.

She switches it off and shoves it into her purse.

Under a streetlight she stops and takes a folded scrap of paper from her coat pocket. An address in her own handwriting, and a time: 1:00. She looks down the street. At the far end, a small lit sign: a bar.

She checks her watch. Early.

The rain thickens. She ducks into the recessed doorway of a closed barbershop, its striped pole dark and still, and presses back into the shadow. Going nowhere. Not yet. She doesn't want to walk in early. She isn't sure she wants to walk in at all.

Somewhere nearby, a pedestrian crossing CHIMES its old melody for an empty intersection. Over and over. No one crosses.

Footsteps. Hurried. Uneven.

An OLD MAN (70s) in a cheap raincoat, one hand pressed to his side as if something is hidden there. He keeps looking back.

He passes Mara's doorway without seeing her. Then, a step later, his eyes find her in the shadow -- a flicker, as if he knows her face -- and he looks away at once and keeps walking, faster, toward the bar sign. Away from her.

At the far end of the alley, headlights. A black sedan pulls across the mouth of the lane and stops, blocking it. Its high beams shine straight down the alley, lighting the rain in long white columns.

Two MEN get out and walk into the alley, black silhouettes against the glare. Black clothes. Masks. They don't run.

The old man stops. He doesn't turn around. He seems to know there is no point. The headlights throw his shadow long down the lane ahead of him.

OLD MAN
(in Japanese; to himself)
Twenty years.

A suppressed SHOT. Flat and ordinary, like a door closing.

The old man folds to his knees, then onto his side in the black water.

In the doorway, Mara has both hands over her mouth.

One of the masked men touches his earpiece.

MASKED MAN
(in Japanese)
First position done. Moving to
second.

They walk back to the car. It reverses out of the alley mouth, unhurried. The headlights swing away, taillights smear red across the wet road beyond, and the alley falls dark.

Rain. The vending machine hum. The crossing melody, still playing for no one.

Mara doesn't move.

Then the old man COUGHS.

She stares. He is still alive.

Every instinct says run. She doesn't. She steps out into the rain and kneels beside him.

She sees his face properly for the first time.

MARA
(whispering)
Mr. Sakai?

MARA
It's okay -- I'll get someone --
(in halting Japanese)
Ambulance. I'll call. Ambulance.

She fumbles for her phone. Switched off. Her hands shake too hard to turn it on.

The old man grips her wrist, stronger than he should be. He presses something small and cold into her palm and folds her fingers around it.

OLD MAN
(in Japanese)
Don't let them have it.

Mara's lips move, working through the words. She understands. Just.

MARA
(in halting Japanese)
Have what? I don't --

He looks at her face as if he is trying to remember it. When he speaks again it is in English, careful and broken, the English of a man who practised it.

OLD MAN
Your father.
(beat)
It was not... what they say.

His grip loosens. His eyes stay open, on nothing.

She opens her hand.

INSERT - THE KEY

A small numbered key on a worn plastic tag. A coin-locker key.

BACK TO SCENE

At the mouth of the alley, headlights swing back.

Mara runs.

Her purse strap snags on the barbershop pole and tears. The purse drops into a puddle behind her. She doesn't stop.

The sedan stops across the alley mouth again. One masked man walks back in to the body and searches the old man's coat, methodically. Nothing.

His flashlight drifts across the street -- and stops on the purse lying in the water.

CUT TO:

2 INT. SMALL BAR, KANDA - CONTINUOUS

2

Six stools and a counter. Shelves of bottles glowing amber. On a high shelf, an old CRT television plays a late-night variety show, sound low. Rain drums on the roof.

No one behind the counter. A door to the back stands half open; someone back there is moving crates.

In the corner, a JOURNALIST (40s), an untouched beer in front of him, a notebook closed beside it. He checks his watch. Checks the door.

The door BANGS open. Mara, soaked, too out of breath to speak.

The journalist half rises. He looks at her -- soaked, foreign, alone -- and something like recognition crosses his face.

JOURNALIST

Miss Voss?

Mara can't answer. She is staring back at the door. Outside, headlights sweep the wet window.

Mara stands dripping, looking for somewhere to go. There is nowhere. She slips behind the far end of the counter and crouches out of sight of the door, her back against the shelves.

She opens her hand. The key. She closes it again.

FROM THE FLOOR, we see only what she sees: the underside of the counter, a crate of empty bottles, the journalist's shoes beneath his stool, and the TV's flickering blue glow on the ceiling.

The door opens again. Softly, this time.

Two pairs of black shoes step inside. Wet. Silent.

The journalist's shoes shift. He stands.

JOURNALIST (O.S.)
(in Japanese)
Where is he?

No answer.

Two suppressed SHOTS.

The stool tips over. The journalist hits the floor on the far side of the counter. We see only his hand.

On the TV, the studio audience LAUGHS.

One pair of shoes crosses to the body. Pages rustle. The notebook, taken.

In the back room, the crate-moving stops.

A pair of shoes turns toward the half-open door. Waits. Nothing moves.

MASKED MAN (O.S.)
(in Japanese; into radio)
Second position done.

The shoes leave. The door swings shut.

Mara stays exactly where she is. She is shaking so hard the bottles in the crate beside her begin to CLINK. She presses her hand flat against them to make them stop.

Her red bird hair clip slides loose and drops silently between the crates. She doesn't notice.

The TV audience laughs again.

HOLD on her face in the blue TV glow: a young woman who has just understood that this was not random.

CUT TO BLACK.

Over black: RAIN.

NEONORE

MAIN TITLES

An old four-story apartment block squeezed between newer buildings. Laundry left out on a balcony, getting rained on. A train slides past on the elevated line behind it, windows lit, and the whole building trembles faintly.

One window on the third floor is lit.

4

INT. VERA'S APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS

4

Small and tidy. Grey light through rain-streaked glass. A smartphone on the table; an old boxy television in the corner. Nothing here quite belongs to one decade.

By the door, in the umbrella stand: a pale blue umbrella. Bone dry.

On a shelf, one framed photograph, its colors gone warm and faded. A Tokyo street, twenty years ago. An American man in a rumpled suit, smiling, holding the hands of two small girls: VERA (9), serious, and MARA (4), mid-laugh. Behind them, the sign of a noodle shop.

VERA VOSS (29) sits at the low table. Two cups. Hers holds cold tea. The other is empty and clean, set out as though someone is expected.

Through the thin wall, a neighbour's radio plays an old ballad, muffled: a woman's voice, a slow saxophone, a song from another decade. Vera doesn't seem to hear it.

Her phone lies face up in front of her. She calls. Waits.

MARA (V.O.)
(recorded; bright)
It's Mara. You know what to do.

BEEP.

Vera opens her mouth. For a moment, nothing.

VERA
It's me again.
(beat)
I'm not angry anymore. I wasn't really angry then, either. Whatever that man wants, it doesn't matter. I just --
(stops herself)
You left your umbrella. You'll get soaked.
(beat)
Just call me. You don't have to say anything. Just call, so I know.

She hangs up.

The old television murmurs to itself.

WEATHER ANNOUNCER (ON TV)
(in Japanese)
...rain continuing through the rest
of the week...

She looks at the umbrella by the door. At the clean, empty cup. At the photograph.

She stands. Puts on her coat. Hesitates at the door.

Then she takes the blue umbrella. Mara's umbrella.

The door closes behind her. Through the wall, the song on the neighbour's radio ends. A DJ murmurs something. Rain.

CUT TO:

5 INT. POLICE STATION, FRONT COUNTER - NIGHT

5

Fluorescent tubes, one of them flickering. A long counter. Faded posters about pickpockets and traffic safety. An old fax machine beside a new flat monitor. A wall clock that runs a minute fast.

Vera stands at the counter, the closed blue umbrella dripping onto the linoleum.

A YOUNG OFFICER takes her details with polite boredom. Vera's Japanese is fluent, but careful and slightly formal -- learned as a child, relearned as an adult.

YOUNG OFFICER
(in Japanese)
Your sister's age?

VERA
(in Japanese)
Twenty-four.

YOUNG OFFICER
(in Japanese)
Adults sometimes go away for a few days. Especially foreigners. It's usually --

VERA
(in Japanese)
She doesn't. Not without telling me.

He types the name. ON THE MONITOR: MARA VOSS.

He stops typing.

He looks at the screen a moment too long. Then he picks up the desk phone and turns away from her.

YOUNG OFFICER
(in Japanese; quietly,
into phone)
Yes. That name. Yes -- the sister
is here now.

He hangs up. His manner has changed. Politer.

YOUNG OFFICER (CONT'D)
(in Japanese)
Someone will be right with you.

Vera looks at him. He doesn't meet her eyes.

6 INT. POLICE STATION, INTERVIEW ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

6

Small. A table, two chairs, a box of tissues nobody has touched in years. Rain on a frosted window.

DETECTIVE ISHIDA (50s) sets a paper cup of tea in front of Vera. Gentle. Unhurried. Tired, in a way that looks like decency.

ISHIDA
You must be cold.

His English is excellent.

VERA
(in Japanese)
I speak Japanese.

ISHIDA
Of course. But this is a difficult
thing. It is easier in your own
language.

A small beat. She lets it go. For now.

VERA
The officer looked at the screen
and made a phone call. Then you
came. What's on the screen?

ISHIDA
Nothing is wrong. We just like to
take care with these things.
(sits)
Voss. You grew up here?

VERA
Until I was nine. What's on the
screen?

He smiles, as if she has passed a small test.

ISHIDA
When did you last see your sister?

VERA
Three days ago. At my apartment. We
had dinner.

ISHIDA
And how did she seem?

Vera hesitates.

VERA
Normal.

Ishida waits, kindly, as if he knows there is more. She
doesn't give it.

ISHIDA
Did she ever mention Kanda? Friends
there? Work?

VERA
Kanda? No. Why --

She stops. Something arrives in her face.

VERA (CONT'D)
The shootings. In Kanda. It was on
the news.

Ishida says nothing. That is its own answer.

VERA (CONT'D)
Is she hurt?

ISHIDA
We have no reason to believe she is
hurt.

VERA
That's not the same as saying she
isn't.

ISHIDA
Miss Voss --

VERA
Is she dead?

ISHIDA
We have no reason to believe she is
dead.

She hears it: the careful, official shape of the sentence.
Her hand tightens around the paper cup.

VERA
Stop saying that. Stop saying what
you have no reason to believe and
tell me what you know.

ISHIDA
What I know is that two men were
killed in Kanda, and that it is a
matter between criminal groups. And
that your sister is a young woman
who has not called her sister for
three days.
(beat)
Those may be two separate things.

VERA
May be.

ISHIDA
May be.

The cup crumples in her fist. Hot tea runs over her fingers
and onto the table. She doesn't seem to feel it.

For the first time in years, someone takes a tissue from the
box. Ishida does, and offers it to her. She doesn't take it.
He sets it down beside her hand.

When she speaks again, it's in Japanese. Low. Precise. Every
word placed.

VERA (CONT'D)
(in Japanese)
She is my sister. I have been
calling her for three days. If you
know where she is, tell me.

Ishida looks at her a long moment. And when he answers, it is in Japanese too, for the first time. Formal. Quiet. A door closing.

ISHIDA
 (in Japanese)
 I do not know where she is. That is the truth.
 (beat)
 And if she saw something she should not have, then the safest place for her is wherever she is now. And the safest thing you can do is nothing.

Silence. Rain on the frosted window.

He switches back to English, gentle again, as if the last minute didn't happen.

ISHIDA (CONT'D)
 Go home, Miss Voss. Keep your phone on. If she calls, call me first. Any hour.

He slides his card across the wet table. She looks at it. Then takes it. Stands. Picks up the blue umbrella.

At the door:

VERA
 You would have told me if she was dead. Wouldn't you?

ISHIDA
 Of course.

She looks at him. She can't tell. She goes. The door closes behind her.

Ishida sits alone a moment. He wipes the spilled tea from the table with the tissue, slowly, carefully, until there is no trace of it.

7

INT. POLICE STATION, DETECTIVES' ROOM - CONTINUOUS

7

Rows of cluttered desks under humming fluorescent light. Most are empty at this hour. A radio plays low somewhere.

Ishida sits at his desk and opens the bottom drawer.

INSERT - THE DRAWER

Sealed in a clear evidence bag: Mara's purse. The torn strap coiled beside it. Still damp.

BACK TO SCENE

He looks at it a long moment. Closes the drawer.

On the wall, the clock runs a minute fast.

CUT TO:

8 INT. SMALL BAR, KANDA - DAY

8

The same bar in flat grey daylight. It looks smaller without the night. Chairs up on the counter. The CRT television is dark.

Where the journalist fell, there is a new rubber floor mat, too clean for this room.

OKADA (60s), the bar's owner, mops around it without looking at it. He has the stillness of a man who hasn't slept.

The door opens. Vera, the blue umbrella in her hand.

OKADA
(in Japanese; not looking
up)
We're closed.

Vera holds up her phone: a photo of Mara, laughing at a party, a paper crown on her head.

VERA
(in Japanese)
My sister. Four nights ago. Was she
here?

Okada looks at the photo for exactly one second.

OKADA
(in Japanese)
No.

VERA
(in Japanese)
You didn't look.

OKADA
 (in Japanese)
 I looked. No.

His eyes go, just once, to the far end of the counter. Then back to the mop.

Vera sees it. She doesn't push. She bows, small and polite, and leaves.

She has left the blue umbrella leaning against a stool.

Okada looks at the umbrella for a long moment.

9 EXT. KANDA STREET - CONTINUOUS

9

Rain. Vera walks away down the narrow street, no umbrella, head down.

OKADA (O.S.)
 (in Japanese)
 Miss.

She turns. Okada stands in the bar doorway holding the blue umbrella, out of breath, as if deciding something cost him more than the walk.

He hands it to her. Then he holds out his other hand. In it: the small red enamel bird clip.

Vera stops breathing.

VERA
 It was mine. She took it when we
 were kids. She never gave it back.

She has said it in English, without realizing. Okada doesn't understand the words. He understands her face.

OKADA
 (in Japanese)
 Behind the counter. After.

VERA
 (in Japanese)
 Did you give this to the police?

OKADA
 (in Japanese)
 They didn't ask.

He takes a business card from his apron and presses it into her hand. Old, soft at the corners, handwritten on the back.

OKADA (CONT'D)
 (in Japanese)
 Not the police. Him.

VERA
 (in Japanese)
 Who is he?

OKADA
 (in Japanese)
 He found my daughter once. When no
 one else would look.

He goes back inside before she can thank him.

Vera looks at the card. Printed in English and in katakana:
 JACK. INVESTIGATIONS. An address. No surname.

10 INT. JACK'S OFFICE - NIGHT

10

Second floor of an old building pressed against the elevated railway. One room. Frosted glass door, JACK hand-lettered on it in English and in katakana.

A desk. A black rotary phone. Filing cabinets. A small CRT television on the cabinet, muted, playing an old black-and-white samurai film. A sofa that has clearly been slept on.

A TRAIN passes outside. The blinds shiver. A spoon rattles in an empty cup. Then silence again.

JACK (48) sits at the desk eating a convenience-store rice ball, watching the silent swordsmen. Handsome once, in a way he stopped maintaining. A good coat, badly kept. He flicks an old steel lighter open and shut, open and shut. There are no cigarettes anywhere.

A knock on the frosted glass. Vera comes in, wet, the blue umbrella dripping.

VERA
 (in Japanese)
 Are you the one they call Jack?

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 Depends who's calling.

VERA
 (in Japanese)
 Mr. Okada. The bar in Kanda.

Jack puts the rice ball down.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Sit down.

She sits. He doesn't switch to English. He lets her speak in the language she chose. She notices.

VERA
(in Japanese)
My sister has been missing for four days. The police say to go home and wait.

JACK
(in Japanese)
I don't do missing persons. People who go missing usually want to.

She places the red bird clip on his desk.

VERA
(in Japanese)
She was in that bar. The night two men were shot there.

Jack looks at the clip for a long moment. The lighter stops.

JACK
(in Japanese)
What did the police tell you?

VERA
(in Japanese)
To go home.

JACK
(in Japanese)
It's good advice.

VERA
(in Japanese)
Is it yours, too?

He doesn't answer. Another train passes. The blinds shiver.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Do you have photographs of her?

She takes an envelope from her bag. As she pulls out the photos, something slides out with them and falls face up on the desk:

The old framed photograph from her shelf, taken out of its frame. Twenty years ago. The American man in the rumpled suit. The two small girls. The noodle shop sign behind them.

Jack looks at it.

He does not move. On the TV behind him, a sword is drawn in total silence.

VERA

That's us. Before we left.

She has slipped into English. So does he, quietly.

JACK

Your father.

VERA

He died. That year. Here.

Jack picks the photograph up by its edges, carefully, the way you'd handle evidence. Or something fragile. He looks a moment too long at the noodle shop sign. Then he sets it down, face up, and squares it to the edge of the desk.

JACK

I'm sorry.

VERA

It was a long time ago.

JACK

Yes.

A beat.

JACK (CONT'D)

Ten thousand yen a day. Plus expenses. I'll need a key to her apartment, her phone number, her friends, where she worked, where she drank.

VERA

So you'll look.

JACK

I'll look.

She gathers the photographs. Leaves the red bird clip where it is. He doesn't give it back, and she doesn't ask.

At the door, she stops.

VERA
Mr. Okada said you found his
daughter.

JACK
I found her.

VERA
Was she alive?

Jack looks at her. The honest answer is in the pause.

JACK
Her Japanese. Your sister's. Is it
good?

VERA
Some. Badly.

JACK
Then she stands out. That helps.

Vera nods. Goes. Through the frosted glass, her shape goes
down the stairs and is gone.

Jack sits very still.

11 INT. JACK'S OFFICE - LATER

11

Past midnight. Only the desk lamp and the grey flicker of the
television, now showing static.

Jack stands on a chair and takes down a cardboard box from
the top of a cupboard. Dust on the lid. He hasn't opened it
in years.

Inside: a police notebook. An old ID card with a younger
face. A folded newspaper clipping.

INSERT - THE CLIPPING

An English-language newspaper, yellowed. A small headline:
AMERICAN INSURANCE INVESTIGATOR FOUND DEAD - POLICE RULE
SUICIDE. A photograph: the same man from Vera's picture. The
caption: DANIEL VOSS, 41.

BACK TO SCENE

Beneath the clipping, one more photograph. Two men at a tiny
noodle counter, laughing, steam in the air: DANIEL VOSS, and
a much younger JACK, still in a cheap police-issue suit.

Behind them, the same noodle shop sign.

Jack looks at it for a long time.

Then he dials the rotary phone. It takes a long time to dial.

ISHIDA (V.O.)
(in Japanese; filtered)
It's late, Jack.

JACK
(in Japanese)
The Voss girl came to see me.

ISHIDA (V.O.)
(in Japanese)
I know.

Silence on the line. Rain on the window.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Her sister was in that bar.

ISHIDA (V.O.)
(in Japanese)
The sister is a missing persons
case. The bar is a gang matter. Two
separate things.

JACK
(in Japanese)
And the old man in the street?

ISHIDA (V.O.)
(in Japanese)
Sakai.
(beat)
Yes. That Sakai. I know what you're
thinking. Old debts, old enemies.
It's a gang matter.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Twenty years, Ishida.

A long pause.

ISHIDA (V.O.)
(in Japanese; gently)
Go to sleep, Jack. You're too old
to be haunted.

The line goes dead.

Jack holds the receiver a moment longer. He sets it down.
Flicks the lighter open. Shut.

A train passes. The photograph of the two laughing men
trembles on the desk.

12 EXT. BACKSTREET, KANDA - NIGHT

12

The street from the cold open. The rain hasn't stopped in
four days.

Jack walks it slowly, a cheap clear plastic umbrella over his
head. Not searching. Looking.

The vending machine at the corner. He feeds it a coin. A can
of hot coffee drops.

VENDING MACHINE
(recorded; in Japanese)
Thank you very much.

He holds the can without drinking it and looks at the spot
where Sakai died. Nothing there now. Rain on asphalt.

He turns and looks at the barbershop doorway. Steps into it.
Stands exactly where Mara stood.

From here, he can see the whole street. And, at the far end,
the small lit sign of Okada's bar.

He looks at the barbershop pole beside him. Crouches.

Caught on a rough metal edge at knee height: a short twist of
torn leather strap.

He doesn't touch it. He looks from the strap, to the spot
where Sakai fell, to the bar sign. Reconstructing it.

A shutter RATTLES up above him. A BARBER (80s), in pajamas,
looks down from the upstairs window.

BARBER
(in Japanese)
Police again?

JACK
(in Japanese)
Not for a long time.

The barber considers him.

BARBER
 (in Japanese)
 I told them. I was asleep. I heard
 the shot. Then a car.

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 One car?

BARBER
 (in Japanese)
 One car. Twice.
 (beat)
 It left. Then it came back.

Jack looks down the empty street.

JACK
 (quietly, in Japanese)
 Why come back?

The barber shrugs and pulls the shutter down.

Jack answers himself, barely aloud.

JACK (CONT'D)
 (in Japanese)
 Because they didn't find it.

He looks again at the doorway. At the bar sign. At the torn strap.

She was here. She saw it. She ran there. She saw that too.

And whatever they came back for, she has it.

He looks down the empty street at the bar sign. And one more question he can't answer yet: what was an American girl doing in a Kanda backstreet at one in the morning?

Jack drops the unopened coffee into the recycling bin. The can CLANKS. The crossing melody starts up somewhere, for no one.

13 INT. THE HIVE, NOODLE SHOP STOREROOM - NIGHT

13

The Hive: a dense, self-built block of stacked homes and workshops, forgotten by the city that grew up around it. We don't see it whole yet. Only this.

A tiny storeroom behind a six-seat noodle counter. Sacks of flour. Crates of green onions. A single bare bulb. Above, close enough to touch, the underside of the elevated railway.

On a thin futon between the flour sacks: Mara. Pale, unwashed, wearing an old cardigan that isn't hers.

The curtain moves. KANEKO (70s), tiny, sharp-eyed, brings in a bowl of noodles, steam rising into the bulb light.

KANEKO
(in Japanese)
Eat.

MARA
(in halting Japanese)
Thank you. Has anyone... come?
Asking?

KANEKO
(in Japanese)
Nobody comes here who isn't lost.

She sets the bowl down. Then, at the curtain, she pauses.

KANEKO (CONT'D)
(in Japanese)
Your father used to sit on the
third stool. He always paid too
much.
(beat)
And your sister always ate
everything on his plate.

Mara almost laughs. It comes out wrong, too close to crying.

MARA
(in halting Japanese)
She told me about this place. All
the time. When we were kids. I
thought it was gone.

KANEKO
(in Japanese)
Everything is going. We are just
slower.

Kaneko goes. The curtain falls shut.

Mara eats three mouthfuls. Stops.

She reaches under the flour sacks and takes out her phone. Looks at it a long time. Then she pulls the futon cover over her head, a child hiding under a blanket, and turns it on.

Under the cover, the screen lights her face blue.

ON THE SCREEN: 31 MISSED CALLS - VERA.

She presses play on the newest voicemail and holds the phone to her ear.

VERA (V.O.)
 (filtered)
 You left your umbrella. You'll get soaked.
 (beat)
 Just call me. You don't have to say anything. Just call, so I know.

Mara's thumb hovers over CALL.

A TRAIN thunders overhead. The bulb swings. Flour dust sifts down through the light like slow snow.

Her thumb doesn't move.

The train passes. Silence.

She turns the phone off. Pushes it deep under the flour sacks. Lies down with her back to the room.

In her fist, the coin-locker key.

HOLD on the swinging bulb as it slowly comes to rest.

CUT TO:

14

INT. MARA'S APARTMENT - DAY

14

A tiny studio in an old building. Grey daylight. Clothes on every surface. Sketches taped to the walls: pencil, charcoal, cheap watercolour. Trains. Rooftops. Laundry lines. Faces on the subway.

The room smells of someone who meant to come back.

Vera stands just inside the door. She hasn't taken her coat off. Jack moves through the room slowly, touching nothing yet. Looking.

JACK
 When were you last here?

VERA
 A week ago. She made me coffee. It was terrible.

Jack opens the fridge. Milk. A half-eaten cake in a box. He closes it.

JACK
She wasn't planning to leave.

VERA
No.

He crouches by the futon. A suitcase underneath, packed and zipped. He looks at it, then at Vera.

VERA (CONT'D)
That was for America. She'd booked a flight. Next month.

JACK
You didn't want her to go.

VERA
I didn't want her to run away again.
(beat)
That's what I said. The night she left. That she always runs.

She looks at the wall of drawings, not at him.

VERA (CONT'D)
It was about Dad. It's always about Dad. She wanted to dig it all up. Who he was here. Why he --
(beat)
I told her to leave him dead.
(beat)
She said I was the one who ran. All the way back here, chasing a ghost, and I won't even look at it.
(beat)
I told her to go, then. Go home. Those were the last things I said to her.

Jack says nothing. He knows better than to comfort it away.

On the desk: a thick sketchbook, its cover soft with use. Jack opens it.

Page after page of the same place. A tiny noodle counter under a railway. Six stools. A curtain. A hand-painted sign. Drawn over and over, from different angles, in different years of her hand -- a child's crayon version taped inside the cover, the newest in careful ink.

JACK
She drew this a lot.

Vera glances over.

VERA

Since she was little. It's from a story I used to tell her. About the noodle shop Dad took us to. She was too young to remember it, so I told her.

(small smile)

She made it up from what I said. It's not real.

Jack turns a page. The sign, in careful ink. Every stroke of the kanji correct.

He has seen this sign. Twice this week. Once in a photograph on Vera's shelf. Once in a box in his own cupboard.

JACK

Can I borrow this?

VERA

Why?

JACK

People draw the places they want to go.

She hesitates, then nods. He closes the sketchbook and puts it under his arm, and says nothing else about it.

15

EXT. THE HIVE - DAY

15

Rain. A wide street of new glass towers and chain stores.

Between two of them, like a gap in someone's teeth: the Hive.

A dense, self-built block of stacked homes and workshops rising eleven storeys, balconies bolted onto balconies, air conditioners and pipes and laundry and hand-painted signs, all of it crushed together under the curve of the elevated railway. The city has grown up around it and forgotten it is there.

At the back, the tower steps down to a low rear wing pressed hard against the concrete railway viaduct, its roof level with the tracks. Old neon signs hang dead on its face. Even in daylight the Hive sits in its own haze of steam and kitchen smoke, as if it had its own weather.

A banner on the construction hoarding next door: a gleaming computer rendering of glass towers where the Hive stands now. A company name: KUROSE DEVELOPMENT. A slogan: TOMORROW'S TOKYO.

Jack stands on the pavement with the sketchbook under his coat. He looks up at the Hive for a long moment, as if at someone he used to know.

Then he goes in.

16 INT. THE HIVE, PASSAGES - CONTINUOUS

16

Narrow corridors, barely shoulder-wide, lit by bare bulbs. Water drips from somewhere above and runs along the floor in a thin shining line. Pipes overhead. Wires everywhere. What daylight gets in comes in thin cold shafts from gaps far overhead, thick with drifting steam.

Doors stand open onto other lives. A MAN at a bench mending radios, a dozen of them murmuring different stations at once. A FAMILY eating dinner at four in the afternoon, the TV loud. An OLD WOMAN asleep in front of a sumo match. A dentist's chair behind a curtain, a hand-lettered price list taped to the wall.

Jack walks through it all. Nobody stops him. Everybody sees him.

A TRAIN passes overhead. The whole building trembles. Dust sifts down through the bulb light. Nobody looks up.

He turns a corner and stops.

The noodle counter. Six stools. The curtain. The hand-painted sign, faded almost to nothing but unmistakable.

It is exactly the drawing.

17 INT. KANEKO'S NOODLE COUNTER - CONTINUOUS

17

Steam. A single fluorescent tube. Two customers slurping in silence at the far end.

Behind the counter, KANEKO works a pot with long chopsticks. She looks up as Jack sits on the third stool.

She looks at him for a long time. Longer than a stranger would.

KANEKO
(in Japanese)
You got old.

JACK
(in Japanese)
So did you.

KANEKO
(in Japanese)
I was already old. You were a boy
in a cheap suit. You came here with
the American.
(beat)
You always sat there. He sat where
you're sitting now.

Jack looks at the counter under his hands.

JACK
(in Japanese)
I'm looking for his daughter. The
younger one.

Kaneko's chopsticks don't pause.

KANEKO
(in Japanese)
The little one? She was four years
old. She ate rice with her fingers.

JACK
(in Japanese)
She's twenty-four now. And someone
wants to kill her.

The two customers at the end of the counter have stopped
slurping.

Kaneko sets a bowl of noodles in front of Jack.

KANEKO
(in Japanese)
Eat. Then go.
(beat)
There is no one here but us.

Jack eats. Slowly. He finishes everything.

He puts down more money than the bowl costs, far more, and a
business card on top of it.

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 He always paid too much, too.

He goes. Kaneko looks at the card for a long moment.

Behind the curtain, in the dark of the storeroom, something moves.

18 INT. JACK'S OFFICE - NIGHT

18

Rain. The old television plays static. Jack sits in the dark, the sketchbook open on the desk.

He turns to the last page. Tucked inside the back cover: a letter, folded small, creased as though it had been crumpled into a ball and smoothed flat again.

He unfolds it under the lamp. Cheap lined paper. Careful, laborious English handwriting.

INSERT - THE LETTER

"Miss Voss. Your father did not kill himself. I can prove it. I have kept his papers for twenty years. I am old and I am ill and I do not want to carry them any more. Please telephone." A phone number. The signature: T. SAKAI.

BACK TO SCENE

The envelope folded inside it is addressed to VERA VOSS.

Jack reads the letter twice. Then he looks at the name on the envelope for a long time.

The black rotary phone RINGS.

He answers. Listens.

KANEKO (V.O.)
 (in Japanese; filtered)
 Come back. Alone. After the last train.

The line clicks dead.

19 INT. KANEKO'S NOODLE COUNTER - NIGHT

19

Past midnight. The shutter half down. The fluorescent tube is off; only a single bulb burns.

Kaneko lifts the curtain to the storeroom and stands aside.

20

INT. THE HIVE, NOODLE SHOP STOREROOM - CONTINUOUS

20

Flour sacks. The futon. The bare bulb.

Mara stands against the far wall with a kitchen knife held in both hands. Not well. Her hands are shaking.

Jack stops in the curtain. He holds his hands open where she can see them.

JACK

My name is Jack. Your sister hired me.

MARA

Prove it.

He takes the red bird clip from his pocket. Holds it out on his open palm.

Mara stares at it. The knife lowers an inch.

JACK

She says it was hers. She says you stole it when you were kids and never gave it back.

Something in Mara's face gives way. The knife drops to her side.

MARA

It was never hers. Dad gave it to me. She just says that.

She almost laughs, and then she is crying, silently, pressing the back of her wrist against her mouth.

Jack waits. He doesn't go to her. He sits down on a flour sack, slowly, making himself smaller.

JACK

Is she okay? Is she -- does she know you're --

MARA

Is she okay?

JACK

She's been calling you. She hasn't slept.

MARA

I know. I listen to them.

JACK

Why were you in Kanda, Mara?

She looks at him. Decides.

MARA

He wrote to Vera. Mr. Sakai. She threw it in the bin without even answering. I took it out.

(beat)

I called him. He said he had Dad's papers. He said to come to the bar at one o'clock. There'd be a man from a newspaper there too, so it couldn't be buried again.

JACK

Vera doesn't know you went.

MARA

We had a fight about it. I called her a coward.

(small, bitter laugh)

And I'm the one hiding in a storeroom.

(beat)

Don't tell her I'm here.

JACK

She's your sister.

MARA

They have my purse. They know my name. They know where I live, where she lives, all of it. If she knows where I am, she'll come here. She won't be able to help it. And they'll follow her.

(beat)

They'll use her to get to me. And then they'll kill her too.

JACK

You don't know that.

MARA

I watched them shoot two men like they were switching off lights.

Silence. The bulb hums.

MARA (CONT'D)

Promise me.

Jack looks at her for a long moment. Twenty years of silence sit behind his eyes.

JACK

I promise.

21 INT. JACK'S OFFICE - DAY

21

Grey light. Rain on the window. Jack hasn't slept. He is in yesterday's shirt.

Footsteps on the stairs. The frosted glass. Vera's shape.

She comes in carrying two coffees in paper cups. She puts one on his desk.

VERA

You look terrible.

JACK

Thank you.

She sits. She doesn't take her coat off. She waits.

VERA

Did you find anything?

The sketchbook is on the desk between them. Jack's hand rests on its cover.

A train passes. The blinds shiver.

JACK

Not yet.

She nods. Believes him. That's the worst part.

VERA

Okay.

(beat)

Okay. Tomorrow, then.

She stands. At the door she hesitates, as though she wants to say something else. She doesn't. She goes.

Jack sits very still. He picks up the coffee she brought him and holds it without drinking, the way he held the can at the vending machine.

22

INT. ALL-NIGHT NOODLE COUNTER, UNDER THE TRACKS - NIGHT

22

A different place: a narrow standing-and-stools counter wedged into a brick railway arch. A ticket machine by the door. Yellowed menus on the wall. A radio behind the counter plays baseball, low.

11:40 p.m. by the clock over the door.

Vera and Jack sit side by side at the counter. Empty bowls. Two coffees in thick white cups. They have been here a long time.

Every few minutes, a train rumbles overhead, and the cups tremble in their saucers.

VERA

He used to bring us somewhere like this. Dad. After work. Mara would fall asleep on the counter and he'd carry her home.

JACK

And you?

VERA

I stayed awake. I wanted to hear everything he said to the man who made the noodles. I didn't understand any of it. I just liked that he was different here. Lighter.

(beat)

I think he was happy here. Before.

Jack looks down at his cup.

VERA (CONT'D)

They said he killed himself. My mother never talked about it. Not once. We went home and it was as if Tokyo never happened.

JACK

Do you believe it?

She thinks about it for a long time.

VERA

I believe he was sad. I don't know
if I believe the rest.

(beat)

A man wrote to me. Last month. An
old man. He said Dad didn't kill
himself. He said he could prove it.

JACK

(carefully)

What did you do?

VERA

I threw it in the bin.

(beat)

Because if it's true, then someone
did it. And nobody looked. Twenty
years, and nobody even looked.

Jack is very still. The letter is in the inside pocket of his
coat. He doesn't move to touch it.

A train. The cups tremble.

VERA (CONT'D)

You're very easy to talk to. It's
annoying.

JACK

I get paid to listen.

VERA

You're not getting paid right now.

He has no answer to that.

She rests her head on her folded arms on the counter. Just
for a moment. Her eyes close.

VERA (CONT'D)

(barely awake)

You're the first person I've
trusted since she disappeared. Did
you know that?

Jack looks at her. His mouth opens. The truth is right there.

JACK

Vera --

But she is asleep.

He sits and watches her breathe. A train passes. Her coffee
cup, near her elbow, trembles toward the edge of the counter.

He reaches over and moves it back from the edge. Carefully. Quietly. So it won't wake her.

He doesn't wake her. He sits there until the counterman begins stacking chairs.

23

EXT. YAKITORI STALL, UNDER THE TRACKS - NIGHT

23

Smoke. Red paper lanterns. Salarymen at plastic tables under a railway bridge, talking too loud.

Ishida sits alone at a corner table with a beer and a plate of skewers. Jack sits down opposite him.

ISHIDA
(in Japanese)
You never call me unless you want something.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Sakai.

Ishida sighs. Turns a skewer over with his chopsticks.

ISHIDA
(in Japanese)
You already know what he was. In the bubble years he cleared land. Old tenants who wouldn't sell. First he'd bring flowers. Then he'd bring men. Then something would happen. A fire, sometimes.

JACK
(in Japanese)
The Shiohama fire.

ISHIDA
(in Japanese)
Among others.
(beat)
The journalist in the bar was from the Toto Shimbun. He'd been asking about the redevelopment money. Who owns what. Whose friends vote on what. The usual. Sakai called him a week ago. We think Sakai wanted to confess something before he died. He had cancer. Months left.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Confess what?

ISHIDA
(in Japanese)
Who knows. An old man's conscience.
It's very common.

Jack watches him.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Why are you telling me all this?

Ishida puts down his chopsticks.

ISHIDA
(in Japanese)
Because you'll find out anyway. And
because I would rather you heard it
from me than from someone who wants
to hurt you.
(beat)
Twenty years ago I told you to sign
that report. You were young. You
did what your senior told you. That
was on me, not on you.

JACK
(in Japanese)
I still signed it.

ISHIDA
(in Japanese)
And I've carried it too. Every day.
(beat)
Whatever Sakai hid, Jack, if you
find it, bring it to me. Not to the
department. To me. I'll know what
to do with it this time.

A long pause. A train roars overhead. The lanterns sway.

Jack nods slowly.

It is exactly what he needed to hear. That is what makes it
dangerous.

The fortieth floor. Glass on three sides. Tokyo spread out
below in the rain like a circuit board.

Silence. Thick carpet. A single orchid.

In the centre of the room, under a glass case: an architectural model of the redevelopment. White towers, green parks, tiny white trees. Where the Hive stands now, there is a plaza with a fountain.

THE CHAIRMAN, KUROSE (70s), stands at the window with his hands behind his back. Silver hair. A beautiful suit. The stillness of a man who has never had to hurry.

Behind him, near the door, stands the MASKED LEADER, unmasked here: a man in his forties in a plain dark suit, a face you would forget immediately. He is the man who touched his earpiece in the rain.

MASKED LEADER

(in Japanese)

The detective went into the Hive twice. Once in the day. Once after the last train.

KUROSE

(in Japanese)

And?

MASKED LEADER

(in Japanese)

We can't follow him in there. Too many people. Too many passages. They see everyone.

KUROSE

(in Japanese)

Then don't follow him in there.

He turns from the window.

KUROSE (CONT'D)

(in Japanese)

Let the detective look. He was always very good at finding things.

(beat)

It's what he does afterwards that he's bad at.

He looks down at the model. At the little plaza where the Hive will be. He straightens one tiny white tree with the tip of his finger.

25

INT. THE HIVE, NOODLE SHOP STOREROOM - NIGHT

25

The bulb. The flour sacks. Mara sits cross-legged on the futon, a bowl of rice going cold in her lap. Jack sits against the opposite wall. They talk quietly, as if the building is listening. It is.

MARA

Mr. Sakai said "twenty years."
Before they shot him. Like he'd
been expecting them for twenty
years.

JACK

He probably had.

MARA

He knew me. He saw me in the
doorway and he walked away from me,
so they wouldn't look. And at the
end he said, in English -- "Your
father. It was not what they say."

Jack looks down at his hands.

MARA

And then in the bar, the man said,
"Where is he?" He was waiting for
the old man. They were supposed to
meet.

JACK

Sakai was bringing him something.

Mara opens her fist. The coin-locker key on its worn plastic tag.

MARA

This.

Jack takes it. Turns it over under the bulb. A number stamped into the metal: 114. The plastic tag is so old the printing has worn away.

JACK

It's not a station locker. They
clear those every three days.

MARA

Then what is it?

JACK

Somewhere he paid for. For a long
time.

He hands it back. She looks surprised.

JACK (CONT'D)
Keep it. Until I know what it
opens. It's safer with you than
with me.

MARA
Why?

JACK
Because nobody knows where you are.

Mara closes her hand around the key. She looks at him properly for the first time.

MARA
Is she eating?

JACK
What?

MARA
Vera. She forgets to eat when she's
upset. She just drinks coffee. Is
she eating?

Jack thinks of the counter at 11:40 p.m. The empty bowls.

JACK
Last night she had noodles.

MARA
Good.
(beat)
Make her eat breakfast. She never
eats breakfast.

26 INT. YAMANOTE LINE TRAIN - DAY

26

A green-striped commuter train circling the city. Rain on the windows. Afternoon light, grey and soft. The carriage is half empty: schoolkids, an old man asleep, a woman with shopping.

Vera and Jack sit side by side. Nowhere to go. Just riding the loop.

VERA
Dad used to do this when he
couldn't think. Ride the whole
loop. An hour. He said Tokyo was a
clock and the Yamanote was the
second hand.

JACK
Did it help?

VERA
I don't know. He did it a lot at
the end.

The train sways. Her shoulder settles against his.

She takes his hand without asking and turns it over. The old steel lighter is in his palm; he has been flicking it without knowing.

She takes it. Opens it. Closes it. Opens it.

VERA (CONT'D)
You don't smoke.

JACK
I quit.

VERA
When?

JACK
Twenty years ago.

VERA
And you still carry the lighter.

JACK
Habit.

VERA
That's not a habit. That's a
promise you don't trust yourself to
keep.

He looks at her. She has no idea how true that is.

She tries to give it back. He closes her fingers around it.

JACK
Keep it.

VERA
Why?

JACK
Because I quit.

She looks at the lighter in her hand. Then she puts it in her coat pocket. And her head comes to rest on his shoulder, as if it has always belonged there.

Out of the window, Tokyo circles past. Rooftops. Laundry. Rain.

27 EXT. PEDESTRIAN CROSSING - DAY 27

A small intersection. The crossing signal turns green and the old melody begins to CHIME.

Vera and Jack cross in the rain, laughing at something, sharing his cheap plastic umbrella that's too small for two. Her shoulder gets wet. His gets wet. Neither of them cares.

WIDE: two small figures crossing an empty road while the city's old song plays for them.

28 EXT. FISHING TOWN, BOSO COAST - DAY 28

Grey sea. Grey sky. Boats pulled up on a concrete slipway. A single road of low houses, their paint scoured by salt wind.

Jack's old car, parked on the sea wall. He gets out, pulls up his collar against the wind, and walks.

29 INT. MRS. SAKAI'S HOUSE - DAY 29

A small room. A kotatsu table. A television with the sound off. A Buddhist altar in the corner: a new photograph of Sakai, younger, smiling in a way that doesn't suit him.

MRS. SAKAI (70s), small and hard, pours Jack tea she doesn't want to pour.

MRS. SAKAI
(in Japanese)
We haven't lived together in
fifteen years. The police already
came.

JACK
(in Japanese)
I'm not the police.

MRS. SAKAI
(in Japanese)
Then what are you?

Jack thinks about it.

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 Someone who owes a man a debt. A
 long time ago. The same kind of
 debt your husband owed.

She studies him. Then she looks at the photograph on the altar.

MRS. SAKAI
 (in Japanese)
 He started going to temple last
 year. Him. Temple. He sat there for
 hours. I thought he'd gone soft in
 the head.
 (beat)
 Last month he wrote a letter. In
 English. Him. He made me check the
 spelling. To an American girl.
 (beat)
 When the doctor told him, he said
 he was glad. He said now he could
 stop being afraid of the wrong
 thing.

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 Did he ever pay rent on something?
 Somewhere that wasn't his home?

She looks at him sharply.

MRS. SAKAI
 (in Japanese)
 Every January. Cash, in an
 envelope. Twenty years. Even the
 years we had nothing, he paid it. I
 thought it was a woman.

She gets up, goes to a drawer, comes back with a thin bundle of old receipts held together with a rubber band. Carbon copies, handwritten, yellowed. She puts them in front of Jack.

MRS. SAKAI (CONT'D)
 (in Japanese)
 He left these here. Maybe on
 purpose.

Jack unfolds the top one. A rubber stamp, faded: KATO RENTAL LOCKERS - UENO. Handwritten: No. 114. Paid in full.

He looks up. She is watching him with an expression he can't read. Grief, maybe. Or relief.

MRS. SAKAI (CONT'D)
 (in Japanese)
 Whatever it is, it was heavier than
 me. He carried it longer.

30 EXT. COUNTRY HIGHWAY - NIGHT 30

Rain. Black fields. Jack's old car, one headlight dimmer than the other, the only thing moving for miles.

Ahead, a light. A sign on a pole, half its bulbs dead: a roadside inn.

31 EXT. ROADSIDE INN - NIGHT 31

Two storeys of weathered wood and a tin roof, set back from the highway behind a gravel lot. A beer vending machine glowing by the entrance. A faded sign. The kind of place that was modern once, in about 1975.

A pickup truck, older than the building's paint, is parked crooked behind it.

Jack pulls into the lot. The only car.

32 INT. ROADSIDE INN, LOBBY - CONTINUOUS 32

A small, warm, faded room. A pink public payphone on the wall. A glass case of souvenir keyrings nobody has bought in decades. A CRT television on a shelf showing a night baseball game, the crowd murmuring.

MRS. NODA (70s) comes out from the back, drying her hands.
 MR. NODA (70s) doesn't look away from the baseball.

MRS. NODA
 (in Japanese)
 Just one night?

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 Just one.

She hands him a heavy old key on a wooden tag.

MRS. NODA
 (in Japanese)
 Upstairs, at the end. The bath is
 shared, I'm sorry. I'll show you.
 The light doesn't work properly.

33 INT. ROADSIDE INN, CORRIDOR AND BATH - CONTINUOUS 33

She leads him down a narrow wooden corridor. Past the kitchen: pots, a steel counter, a back door with a bolt.

MRS. NODA
(in Japanese)
Kitchen. If you want tea, just take it. The back door sticks. My husband says he'll fix it. He's said so since the Olympics.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Which Olympics?

MRS. NODA
(in Japanese)
Exactly.

She opens a door: a small tiled bathroom, a deep wooden tub, one high window over it, fogged with steam and swollen shut in its frame.

MRS. NODA (CONT'D)
(in Japanese)
If it's too steamy, the window opens. If you hit it hard enough.

Jack notices the window. He notices everything. That is the point of the scene, and nobody in it knows it.

34 INT. ROADSIDE INN, JACK'S ROOM - NIGHT 34

Tatami. A low table. A thin futon already laid out. Rain loud on the tin roof.

Jack sits at the table with Sakai's receipts spread out in front of him under the lamp. KATO RENTAL LOCKERS - UENO. No. 114. Twenty years of Januaries.

He takes out his phone. No signal.

35 INT. ROADSIDE INN, LOBBY - NIGHT 35

Mr. Noda asleep in front of the baseball. Jack at the pink payphone, feeding it coins.

INTERCUT WITH:

36 INT. VERA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

36

Vera on the floor with her back against the bed, the apartment dark around her. Her phone rings. Unknown number. She answers fast.

VERA
Mara?

JACK (V.O.)
It's me.

A beat. Disappointment, then something else.

VERA
Where are you? You sound like
you're calling from 1985.

JACK
The countryside. There's no signal.
I'm on a payphone. It's pink.

She almost laughs.

VERA
Did you find anything?

Jack looks at the receipts in his hand.

JACK
Maybe. I'll know tomorrow.

VERA
Come back safe.

JACK
It's just an inn. There's an old
couple and a baseball game.

VERA
Come back safe anyway.

He hears her breathing on the line. Neither of them hangs up.

The coins run out. The line goes dead.

Vera looks at the phone. Jack looks at the payphone. Both of them hold on a moment longer than they need to.

37 INT. ROADSIDE INN, KITCHEN DOORWAY - NIGHT

37

Jack can't sleep. He wanders back down the corridor.

The kitchen's back door stands open to the rain. Mrs. Noda sits on the step outside under the eave, smoking.

MRS. NODA
(in Japanese)
Don't tell my husband.

JACK
(in Japanese)
I quit.

MRS. NODA
(in Japanese)
Then you'll understand why I don't
want him to know.

She offers the pack anyway. He shakes his head. He stands in the doorway and looks out: a muddy yard, a gate onto a farm track, and the old pickup parked crooked across the path.

MRS. NODA (CONT'D)
(in Japanese)
Sorry about the truck. He parks it
like he's drunk. He's never drunk.
The keys are always in it. Who
would steal that?

Jack looks at the truck. He says nothing.

38 EXT. ROADSIDE INN - NIGHT

38

Later. 2 a.m. Rain.

The highway. Empty. Then headlights.

One car. Two. Three. Four. Black sedans, one after another, slowing, turning in, gravel crunching.

39 INT. ROADSIDE INN, JACK'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

39

Jack's eyes open in the dark. He has heard the gravel.

He goes to the window. Lifts one corner of the thin curtain.

HIS POV THROUGH THE CURTAIN GAP: four black cars in an arc across the lot, headlights on, rain visible only inside the beams. Eight MEN step out, two from each car. Black clothes. Masks. Compact submachine guns held low and easy.

They don't rush. They split without speaking. Two toward the entrance. Two around the back. Two toward the side. Two stay by the cars.

Jack lets the curtain fall.

He moves fast and quietly: sweeps the receipts into his jacket, pulls on his shoes, takes nothing else.

Downstairs, the baseball crowd CHEERS on the TV.

40 INT. ROADSIDE INN, LOBBY - CONTINUOUS 40

The front door opens. Two masked men step in, weapons up.

Mr. Noda wakes in his chair. Stares.

MR. NODA
(in Japanese)
We're closed --

A burst of suppressed fire into the ceiling. Plaster rains down. Mr. Noda throws himself behind the counter.

The souvenir case shatters. The CRT keeps playing baseball.

41 INT. ROADSIDE INN, UPSTAIRS CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS 41

Jack at the top of the stairs. He hears boots below. He goes the other way, toward the bath.

Behind him, a masked man reaches the top of the stairs and fires down the corridor. The paper screens along one wall burst apart in a line of holes.

Jack is already through the bathroom door.

42 INT. ROADSIDE INN, BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS 42

Dark. Steam still hanging. Jack climbs onto the edge of the deep tub and hits the swollen window frame with the heel of his hand. Once. Twice. It won't move.

Boots in the corridor.

The third time, he hits it with everything he has. The frame cracks open. Rain pours in.

He hauls himself through.

43 EXT. ROADSIDE INN, KITCHEN ROOF - CONTINUOUS 43

A low slope of wet tin below the bathroom window. Jack drops onto it, slides, catches the gutter, and swings down --

44 INT. ROADSIDE INN, KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

44

-- through the open back door into the kitchen, where Mrs. Noda is crouched on the floor behind the steel counter, rigid with fear.

He grabs her arm, pulls her low toward the pantry, opens it, puts her inside.

JACK
(in Japanese; whispered)
Stay. Whatever you hear.

MRS. NODA
(in Japanese; whispered)
My husband --

JACK
(in Japanese; whispered)
I'll get him.

He closes the pantry door on her.

He moves up the corridor toward the lobby, keeping low along the wall.

45 INT. ROADSIDE INN, LOBBY - CONTINUOUS

45

From the corridor, Jack can see the lobby. One masked man stands in the middle of the room, weapon up, covering the stairs. The other has gone up.

Mr. Noda is behind the counter, out of the gunman's line of sight. He sees Jack. Jack puts a finger to his lips.

Jack reaches out and flips the lobby light switch. DARK.

Only the TV lights the room now: blue, flickering.

The masked man spins and fires toward the corridor. The shots stitch across the wall above Jack's head. One tears through the beer vending machine by the door.

It lights up and CHIMES:

VENDING MACHINE
(recorded; in Japanese)
Thank you very much.

The gunman flinches toward the sound.

In that half-second, Jack is across the dark lobby, behind the counter. He grabs Mr. Noda by the collar and drags him down the corridor.

On the wall, the pink payphone starts to RING.

No one answers it. It rings and rings.

46 INT. ROADSIDE INN, KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS 46

Jack pushes Mr. Noda into the pantry beside his wife. The old couple clutch each other in the dark.

Jack looks at them.

JACK
(in Japanese)
I'm sorry.

He shuts the door. He goes out the back.

47 EXT. ROADSIDE INN, BACK YARD - CONTINUOUS 47

Rain. Mud. The farm gate. The pickup truck.

A masked man comes round the side of the building. Sees him.

Jack runs. Gunfire kicks up mud behind him. He dives behind the truck. Bullets punch through the bodywork above his head, through the tailgate, through a wheel.

He yanks open the driver's door and pulls himself in, flat along the seat.

48 INT. PICKUP TRUCK - CONTINUOUS 48

The keys are in the ignition, exactly where she said.

He turns them. The engine coughs. Dies.

The windscreen cracks as a round goes through it.

JACK
(under his breath)
Come on. Come on.

He turns the key again. The engine catches. Roars.

49 EXT. ROADSIDE INN, BACK YARD - CONTINUOUS

49

The truck lurches forward and smashes through the farm gate. Two masked men throw themselves aside. The truck fishtails through the mud onto the farm track, then onto the highway.

The eight men walk out into the lot, one by one, and stand in the headlights of their cars, watching the single red taillight shrink into the rain.

They don't chase him. They don't need to.

The MASKED LEADER touches his earpiece.

MASKED LEADER
(in Japanese)
He's gone. He has what she gave
him.

Behind them, inside the lobby, the pink payphone is still ringing.

50 INT. PICKUP TRUCK - MOVING - DAWN

50

Grey light. Empty highway. Rain through the shattered windscreen.

Jack drives with one hand. Blood runs from his hairline down the side of his face. His shirt is dark with it at the shoulder.

He looks in the mirror. No one.

He reaches into his jacket. The receipts are still there, soaked and creased.

He breathes. Only now does his hand start to shake.

Then the thought arrives, and his face changes.

Only two people knew where he was going tonight. He counts them silently.

Ishida. He asked Ishida for the widow's address.

And Vera. He called her from a pink payphone and told her it was just an inn.

He drives on. The wipers beat. He doesn't want to think it. He thinks it anyway.

51 INT. CHAIRMAN'S OFFICE, KUROSE DEVELOPMENT - DAWN

51

The glass walls grey with dawn. Kurose sits in a leather chair beside the model of the redevelopment, a cup of tea on the arm of the chair.

Standing before him, hat in hand, raincoat still wet:
Detective ISHIDA.

It is the first time we see them together. It explains everything.

ISHIDA
(in Japanese)
I told you. Leave him alone. Let
him find it.

KUROSE
(in Japanese)
You told me he was tired, Ishida.
That he had given up twenty years
ago. He doesn't look tired to me.

ISHIDA
(in Japanese)
He trusts me. He'll bring it to me.
He said so.
(beat)
Then we take both. The girl and the
thing.

Kurose sips his tea. He looks down at the model: the little plaza with its fountain where the Hive still stands.

KUROSE
(in Japanese)
You were always very careful. I
hope you still are.

Ishida bows. Holds the bow a moment too long.

52 INT. VERA'S APARTMENT - DAWN

52

A knock at the door. Vera opens it in a sweater, barely awake.

Jack. Soaked. Blood dried down the side of his face.

VERA
Oh my God.

She pulls him in.

53

INT. VERA'S APARTMENT, BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

53

A small tiled bathroom. Jack sits on the closed toilet. Vera kneels in front of him with a bowl of warm water and a cloth, cleaning the cut at his hairline.

He watches her face while she works. Very closely. As though he is trying to read something written there.

VERA

Who did this?

JACK

I don't know.

VERA

You don't know?

JACK

Eight men. Masks. They didn't introduce themselves.

She wrings out the cloth. Pink water.

VERA

You told me it was just an inn.

JACK

It was just an inn.

She looks up and catches him watching her.

VERA

What?

He doesn't answer. He's still watching. Measuring. She sees something in his look that she doesn't understand, and it frightens her more than the blood.

VERA (CONT'D)

Jack. What?

He looks at her hands: careful, steady, stained pink. At her face: exhausted, afraid for him.

Whatever he was looking for, it isn't there. It was never there.

JACK

Nothing.

(beat)

I'm sorry. Nothing.

She puts a plaster on the cut, very gently. Her hand stays on his face a moment after.

He covers her hand with his.

And then, without either of them deciding, she kisses him. Or he kisses her. It doesn't matter which.

It is quiet, and brief, and it changes everything.

When it ends, she rests her forehead against his.

VERA
Don't go anywhere else without
telling me.

JACK
I won't.

It is another promise. He is collecting them.

54 EXT. OLD TOBACCO KIOSK - DAY

54

A tiny kiosk wedged into the corner of a shopping arcade. An OLD TOBACCONIST (80s) behind a window full of cigarette cartons and lottery tickets.

Vera holds up the old photograph. The American man, two small girls, the noodle shop sign.

VERA
(in Japanese)
My father worked near here, a long
time ago. Do you know this place?

The tobacconist puts on his glasses. Looks. Smiles with all his remaining teeth.

OLD TOBACCONIST
(in Japanese)
Kaneko's. Of course. In the Hive.
(beat)
Not for long, though. They're
knocking it all down.

Vera stares at him.

VERA
(in Japanese)
It's still there?

OLD TOBACCONIST
 (in Japanese)
 Everything is still there. Until it
 isn't.

55 INT. THE HIVE, PASSAGES - DAY 55

Vera walks through the narrow corridors with the photograph in her hand, looking at everything as though she's trying to remember it. Bare bulbs. Dripping water. The radio repairman's dozen murmuring stations. Daylight falls in thin cold shafts through the steam.

A train passes overhead. The building trembles.

She stops. Turns a corner.

The noodle counter. The sign.

She stands there for a long moment, holding the photograph up beside the real thing. They match.

56 INT. KANEKO'S NOODLE COUNTER - CONTINUOUS 56

Lunchtime. Steam. Three customers.

Vera sits on the third stool.

Kaneko turns from the pot, sees her, and freezes. Just for a second. Then she goes on working.

VERA
 (in Japanese)
 I'm sorry, I don't know what to
 order. I was here when I was a
 child. With my father. He always
 sat here.

Kaneko looks at her for a long moment.

KANEKO
 (in Japanese)
 He always paid too much.

Vera's breath catches.

VERA
 (in Japanese)
 You remember him?

KANEKO
 (in Japanese)
 And you. You ate everything on his
 plate.

She sets a bowl of noodles in front of Vera. Vera looks at it. Her eyes fill.

57 INT. THE HIVE, NOODLE SHOP STOREROOM - CONTINUOUS 57

On the other side of the curtain, three feet away.

Mara stands pressed against the wall with both hands over her mouth. She has heard her sister's voice. She is shaking.

Through the thin gap at the edge of the curtain she can see the back of Vera's head. The third stool.

Mara takes one step toward the curtain. Her hand lifts to it. She stops.

She thinks of the purse in the rain. Of the two men falling. Of her sister being followed through these corridors.

Her hand drops.

58 INT. KANEKO'S NOODLE COUNTER - CONTINUOUS 58

Vera eats. All of it. She laughs once, at nothing, wiping her eyes.

VERA
 (in Japanese)
 My sister would love this place.
 She's never seen it. She only knows
 it from my stories.
 (beat)
 When I find her, I'll bring her
 here.

Kaneko's chopsticks stop moving in the pot. She doesn't look up.

KANEKO
 (in Japanese)
 Yes. Bring her.

Vera puts money on the counter. Too much. Kaneko notices and says nothing.

Vera goes, lighter than she has been for the whole film.

Behind the curtain, Mara slides down the wall to the floor.

59

EXT. THE HIVE - CONTINUOUS

59

Rain. Vera comes out of the Hive's narrow entrance, glowing.

Jack is coming the other way, fast, soaked. He sees her. He stops dead.

VERA

Jack! It's still here. The noodle shop from the photo. It's real. The same woman -- she remembered Dad. She remembered me.

She is so happy. She throws her arms around him.

Over her shoulder, Jack looks at the entrance of the Hive. At the street. At the rain. At every parked car.

VERA (CONT'D)

When we find Mara, I'm bringing her here. She'll finally see it.

JACK

(quietly)

Yes.

He holds her. His face, over her shoulder, is the face of a man at the edge of a very high place.

60

INT. THE HIVE, NOODLE SHOP STOREROOM - NIGHT

60

The bulb. Mara sits on the futon with her knees pulled up. Her face is swollen from crying. Jack crouches in front of her.

MARA

She was right there. She was right there and I --

JACK

You did the right thing.

MARA

Did I?

(beat)

She said she'd bring me here. When she finds me. She was so happy.

She wipes her face with the heel of her hand.

JACK
If she found this place, other
people can.

MARA
I know.

She opens her hand. The key. Number 114.

MARA (CONT'D)
Find what it opens. And then this
ends. I don't want to hide any
more. I want my sister.

Jack takes the key.

JACK
Tomorrow night I'm moving you out
of here. Somewhere safe, outside
Tokyo. A police car and a house.
Someone I trust.

MARA
And then?

JACK
And then I tell her everything.

Mara looks at him. She believes him.

61 INT. ISHIDA'S CAR - NIGHT

61

Parked under an elevated expressway. Rain drumming on the
roof. The dashboard glow.

Ishida behind the wheel. Jack in the passenger seat. Neither
looks at the other.

JACK
(in Japanese)
I have a witness. From the bar.

A pause. Ishida's expression doesn't change at all. That is
the tell, and only we know it.

ISHIDA
(in Japanese)
The sister.

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 I need a safe car. A safe house
 outside the city. No paperwork. No
 department. Just you.

ISHIDA
 (in Japanese)
 When?

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 Tomorrow night.

Ishida nods slowly, as if thinking it through. As if it costs
 him something.

ISHIDA
 (in Japanese)
 Nine o'clock. The service road
 behind the Hive, by the railway
 pillars. A grey car. My driver.
 I'll arrange the house myself.
 (beat)
 And Sakai's thing?

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 I'll bring it to you. When she's
 safe.

ISHIDA
 (in Japanese)
 Good.
 (beat)
 You've done well, Jack. This time
 you've done well.

Jack looks out at the rain. For the first time in twenty
 years, he lets himself believe it.

62 EXT. PEDESTRIAN CROSSING - NIGHT

62

The same small intersection as before. The signal is red.
 Vera and Jack stand at the kerb under his cheap plastic
 umbrella.

JACK
 Tomorrow night. Will you have
 dinner with me?

She looks at him, surprised.

VERA
Like a date?

JACK
Like a date.

VERA
Jack, my sister --

JACK
I know.
(beat)
There's something I need to tell
you. I want to tell you properly.
Not in an office. Not on a train.

She searches his face. Whatever she finds there makes her
smile. Properly. For the first time in the film.

VERA
Okay.

JACK
The old hotel by the station. The
lounge. Ten o'clock.

VERA
Ten o'clock.

The signal turns green. The old melody begins to CHIME.

They cross. She takes his arm.

63 INT. KATO RENTAL LOCKERS, UENO - NIGHT

63

A narrow room under a railway arch, lined floor to ceiling
with battered grey steel lockers, each one numbered in fading
paint. A single fluorescent tube. A sign in faded letters:
MONTHLY. YEARLY. NO QUESTIONS.

At a desk by the door, a CARETAKER (80s) sleeps with his head
on a ledger.

Jack walks the rows. 98. 106. 112. 114.

He fits the key. It turns stiffly, as though it hasn't turned
in years.

The door creaks open.

Inside: a small cardboard box, softened with age. Jack lifts
the lid.

A single cassette tape in a cracked plastic case, labelled in a shaking hand: SHIOHAMA. And beneath it, a notebook with a worn cloth cover.

Jack opens the notebook. English handwriting. Neat, slanted, careful. Dates. Names. Diagrams of a burned building.

On the inside cover: DANIEL VOSS.

Jack stands very still.

He turns pages. The handwriting grows faster, more anxious. And then a page near the end, and a line underlined twice.

He reads it. We don't see what it says. We see his face.

He closes the notebook.

A train passes overhead. The lockers rattle in their rows, all of them at once, like a room full of doors being tried.

64 INT. SMALL BAR, KANDA - NIGHT

64

Okada's bar. Late. No customers. The CRT television is off.

Jack slides the cassette case across the counter.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Keep this for me. Don't tell
anyone. Not the police. Not me, if
I ask you with someone standing
behind me.

Okada looks at the tape. Then he takes it, lifts the lid of the old cash drawer, removes the tray, and puts the tape underneath.

OKADA
(in Japanese)
Behind the counter. Like the girl's
clip.

He pours Jack a drink. Jack doesn't drink it.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Tomorrow it'll be over.

OKADA
(in Japanese)
That's what people say the night
before.

65 INT. VERA'S APARTMENT - EVENING

65

Rain on the window. The last grey light.

Vera stands on a chair and lifts down a flat cardboard box from the top of the wardrobe. Dust on the lid. Her mother's handwriting on the side, in marker: TOKYO.

She opens it on the bed.

Inside, folded in tissue paper that has gone yellow: a dress. Wine red. Silk. The kind of dress a young woman wore to an expensive restaurant in 1990 and never wore again.

Vera holds it up against herself in the mirror. For a moment she is someone else. Her mother, maybe.

Through the thin wall, the neighbour's radio begins to play the same old ballad from before: the woman's voice, the slow saxophone.

LATER:

Vera at the small mirror by the window, in the red dress, doing her makeup. She is out of practice. She wipes off the lipstick and does it again. Her hands aren't quite steady.

She looks at herself for a long time. She almost looks happy. She doesn't quite trust it.

She picks up her bag. Puts in her phone. Then, after a moment, the old steel lighter.

At the door she stops by the umbrella stand. The pale blue umbrella.

She takes it.

VERA
(quietly, to the empty
room)
Borrowing it. You'll get it back.

She goes. Through the wall, the song plays on.

66 INT. HOTEL LOUNGE - NIGHT

66

An old hotel built in the Showa years for a future that never quite came. Amber light. Brass rails. Deep leather chairs. Bottles glowing behind the bar like a shrine.

In the corner, a PIANIST (60s) in a white jacket plays standards, softly, to almost no one.

A clock above the bar: 9:58.

Vera comes in, shaking the rain from the blue umbrella. People turn to look at her, briefly. She is beautiful and doesn't know where to put her hands.

She sits at the bar. Leans the blue umbrella against the next stool.

BARTENDER
(in Japanese)
For you?

VERA
(in Japanese)
I'm waiting for someone.
(beat)
A gin and tonic. Please.

She looks at the door.

The clock: 10:00.

67 EXT. SERVICE ROAD BEHIND THE HIVE - NIGHT

67

Earlier. The clock is a different clock here: 8:52 on a lit sign above a closed garage.

A narrow road running under the elevated railway. A row of massive concrete pillars. Puddles. One sodium lamp.

A grey sedan waits beside the pillars, engine running, wipers slow.

68 INT. THE HIVE, NOODLE SHOP STOREROOM - CONTINUOUS

68

Mara puts on a borrowed coat. She has a small cloth bag: a toothbrush, the cardigan, the sketchbook pages she tore from the wall.

Kaneko stands in the curtain. She hands Mara a small parcel wrapped in newspaper.

KANEKO
(in Japanese)
Rice balls. For the car.

Mara takes them. She doesn't know what to say.

MARA
(in halting Japanese)
Thank you. For --

KANEKO
 (in Japanese)
 Come back with your sister. Sit on
 the stools. Both of you. Eat
 everything.

Mara bows, too deep, clumsy. Kaneko, unexpectedly, puts a
 hand on her head. Just for a second. Like a grandmother.

JACK (O.S.)
 It's time.

69 INT. THE HIVE, PASSAGES - NIGHT

69

Jack leads Mara through the narrow corridors. Bare bulbs.
 Dripping pipes. The radio repairman looks up from his bench
 as they pass, and nods.

Doors open onto other lives. A family watching television. A
 man asleep. A girl practising the violin, badly.

Mara looks at all of it as if memorising it.

MARA
 Vera would love this.

JACK
 You can bring her.

MARA
 When it's over, you'll tell her?
 Everything?

JACK
 Tonight. I'm meeting her at ten.

She stops walking. Looks at him.

MARA
 Meeting her?

JACK
 For dinner.

Mara studies him. And then, for the first time, she smiles. A
 real one. Her sister's smile.

MARA
 Oh. Oh, I see.

JACK
 It's not --

MARA
 It is. It's fine. It's good.
 (beat)
 She deserves someone who looks for
 things.

A train passes overhead. The building trembles. They walk on.

70

EXT. SERVICE ROAD BEHIND THE HIVE - CONTINUOUS

70

Jack and Mara come out of a narrow back door of the Hive into the rain.

The grey sedan waits beside the pillars, twenty metres away. A DRIVER in a dark coat gets out and opens the rear door for them. Polite. Professional.

Jack walks Mara toward it. Halfway there.

The driver lifts his wrist to his mouth and murmurs into his sleeve, very quietly:

DRIVER
 (in Japanese)
 Position.

Mara stops dead.

She has heard that word before. In the rain. Over a dying man.

MARA
 (whispering)
 That's them.

JACK
 What?

MARA
 That's what they said. Position.
 That's them.

Jack looks at the driver. The driver looks at Jack. And in that look, both men understand.

Jack shoves Mara back toward the Hive door.

JACK
 Run!

From the dark between the pillars: muzzle flashes. Suppressed shots, flat and ordinary.

Jack draws Mara down behind a dumpster. Rounds clang off the steel. The driver pulls a weapon from his coat.

Mara breaks for the Hive door. Five metres. Three.

A shot.

She stumbles. Keeps going. Falls through the doorway.

Jack goes after her, low, as bullets chew the doorframe above his head.

71 INT. THE HIVE, PASSAGE - CONTINUOUS

71

Jack drags the door shut behind him and throws the bolt. Pounding on the door. Shots through it, splintering the wood.

Mara is on the floor of the narrow passage, her back against the wall. She is holding her side. Her hand is dark and wet.

Jack kneels, presses his hands over hers.

JACK

Stay with me. Mara. Stay with me.

Above them, a window opens. Then another. Doors bang open along the passage. Voices. Lights snap on, one after another, up through the whole building: the thousand windows of the Hive waking.

The RADIO REPAIRMAN runs into the passage with a flashlight. The FAMILY'S FATHER behind him with a baseball bat. Kaneko, in her apron.

Outside, a car door slams. An engine revs. Tyres on wet asphalt. Going.

And far away, finally, sirens.

Mara looks up at all the light.

MARA

Everyone's awake.

JACK

Yes. Everyone's awake. Help's coming.

Mara's hand finds his wrist. Her grip is weak.

MARA

Jack.

JACK
I'm here.

MARA
Tell her I'm sorry.

JACK
You'll tell her. Tonight. I'll
bring her here, you can --

MARA
Tell her.

Her eyes stay on the lights above. Then they stop moving.

Jack doesn't let go of her hand.

Kaneko sinks down beside them in the narrow passage. She doesn't cry. She takes off her apron and folds it and places it gently under Mara's head, as though that still matters.

A train passes overhead. The bulbs swing. The whole building trembles, the way it always does.

72 INT. HOTEL LOUNGE - NIGHT

72

The clock above the bar: 11:52.

Vera's gin and tonic sits untouched. The ice has melted. The lime has sunk.

The pianist plays something slow. The same old ballad from the neighbour's radio, only now on a piano, stripped of its words.

Vera looks at the door. At her phone. No messages.

She takes out the lighter and turns it over in her fingers. Open. Shut.

BARTENDER
(in Japanese)
Another?

VERA
(in Japanese)
No. Thank you.

She almost laughs at herself. She looks down at the red dress. She feels foolish, and then hurt, and then angry.

Her phone RINGS.

She grabs it. The screen: ISHIDA.

Her face changes. She answers.

VERA (CONT'D)
Hello?

ISHIDA (V.O.)
(filtered; gently)
Miss Voss. I'm so sorry to call so late.

She knows. From his voice, she already knows. She stands up.

ISHIDA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Your sister was found tonight. I'm very sorry. She died a short time ago.

Vera doesn't move. The piano plays on.

ISHIDA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
She was with Mr. Jack. He had been hiding her for several days, it seems. In the Hive.
(beat)
I'm sorry. I thought you knew.

The phone slowly lowers from her ear.

The pianist plays. The clock ticks. Somewhere a glass is set down.

Vera walks out of the lounge. Not running yet. Walking very carefully, as if the floor might give way.

The blue umbrella stays where she left it, leaning against the empty stool.

73 EXT. TOKYO STREETS - NIGHT

73

Vera comes out of the hotel into the rain and starts to run.

Not elegantly. Badly. In heels, in the red dress, no coat, no umbrella. Slipping. Stumbling. Stopping for half a second because she can't breathe, then forcing herself on.

Rain plasters her hair to her face. Her mascara runs.

No music. Only rain. Her heels on wet pavement. Her breath. A car passing, its tyres hissing.

She runs past a vending machine. It glows, indifferent.

At a crossing, the old melody chimes for her, and she runs through it on red.

One heel skids. Her ankle turns. The shoe comes off and stays behind in a puddle. She doesn't stop. She runs on in one shoe.

74

EXT. EMPTY STREET UNDER THE TRACKS - NIGHT

74

A long, empty street beside the elevated railway. Shuttered shops. A row of vending machines, their cold white light the only light, rain falling through it in columns. The black road shining like water.

In a city of fourteen million people, no one else is here.

Jack walks out of the dark from the direction of the Hive. His coat is soaked. His hands are dark. He has not washed them.

He sees her at the far end of the street.

He stops under the awning of a closed shop.

Vera slows. Stops. Twenty metres apart.

For a moment neither of them says anything. She is crying, almost silently.

Jack takes one step toward her.

She shakes her head.

VERA

Don't.

He stops.

She looks at him. There is something almost childlike in her face now. Not rage. Disbelief. As though she is still hoping he will tell her that what she's heard is wrong.

She walks toward him. Slowly. One shoe, one bare foot on the wet road.

VERA (CONT'D)

You knew.

Jack doesn't answer.

Her face changes. That silence is the answer.

She hits him. Not a big cinematic slap. One desperate blow against his chest with her fist.

He takes it.

She hits him again. Then again.

VERA (CONT'D)
You knew where she was.

He says nothing. He can't. Behind his silence is a promise to a dead girl, and the audience knows it, and Vera doesn't.

She hits him again, weaker. And then the anger drains out of her all at once. Her hands just fall.

VERA (CONT'D)
(whispering)
Why didn't you tell me?

Jack opens his mouth. Nothing comes.

VERA (CONT'D)
She was waiting for me.

That line is almost inaudible.

Jack looks away.

VERA (CONT'D)
And I was waiting for you.
(beat)
And you were with her.

Jack closes his eyes.

And that is when Vera finally breaks. Not screaming. She simply folds. Her knees hit the wet pavement.

Jack drops down instinctively, reaching for her.

Her hands grab the front of his coat. She holds on. For one second it looks as if she is going to let him hold her.

Then she realises whose coat it is.

She pushes him away.

And sits there, in the rain, in the red dress.

Jack kneels a few feet away. He doesn't touch her again.

WIDE. EXTREME WIDE.

Two small figures on a huge, empty, shining street. The vending machines hum. The rain falls through their light.

Every sound drops away except the rain.

In the black water beside Vera, her reflection. And in the reflection, for less than a second, the street is slightly different: a shutter open that is closed, a warm light in a window that is dark, and a figure under a pale blue umbrella who could be Mara, or could be no one.

It is gone.

Vera covers her face with her hands.

Above them, an elevated train passes, a long ribbon of lit windows. Inside, strangers sleep, read, stare at their phones. Nobody looks down.

Only now does the SCORE enter: sparse and mournful, as if coming from very far away.

The shot holds. Long enough that it becomes hard to watch. There is nothing Jack can say. Nothing that fixes it.

75 INT./EXT. VARIOUS - NIGHT - SERIES OF SHOTS

75

Still frames. No people.

-- A single red high-heeled shoe lying in a puddle on an empty street, rain dimpling the water around it.

-- The hotel lounge, empty, the chairs up. The pale blue umbrella still leaning against the bar stool.

-- The Hive at night, the noodle shop shutter down, its old sign still faintly glowing.

-- The vending machine on the empty street, humming, lit, waiting for no one.

-- A small television in a shop window, showing only static.

CUT TO BLACK.

76 INT. VERA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

76

Darkness. Rain on the window.

Vera sits on the floor with her back against the bed, still in the ruined red dress, mascara dried on her face. One shoe.

In her hand, the old steel lighter.

She opens it. Closes it. Opens it.

She should throw it away. She holds it against her chest instead, and bends over it, and cries without making a sound.

She still loves him. She hates herself for it.

77 INT. JACK'S OFFICE - NIGHT

77

The desk lamp. Static on the TV. Jack sits in his wet coat at the desk. He still hasn't washed his hands.

On the desk: Daniel Voss's notebook.

He hears her voice. Over and over. Not the words from tonight. The words from the noodle counter at 11:40.

VERA (V.O.)
You're the first person I've
trusted since she disappeared.

He opens the drawer. Takes out a clean envelope. Puts the notebook inside.

He picks up a pen to write something on the envelope. He holds it over the paper for a long time.

He writes nothing.

78 EXT. VERA'S APARTMENT BUILDING, CORRIDOR - DAWN

78

Grey light. An open-air walkway along the third floor. Rain dripping from the railing.

Vera opens her door. She is still in the dress. She hasn't slept.

On the doormat: a plain envelope. No name.

She picks it up. Opens it. The cloth-covered notebook. And tucked inside its cover, a folded sheet of lined paper.

She sees the name inside the cover, and her whole body goes still.

DANIEL VOSS.

79

INT. VERA'S APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS

79

Vera sits at the low table in the dawn light. Beside her, the two cups from the beginning of the film, both empty now.

She unfolds the lined paper first.

Careful, laborious English handwriting. "Miss Voss. Your father did not kill himself. I can prove it."

It is the letter she threw away. Smoothed flat by someone else's hands.

She understands, all at once, why her sister was in a Kanda backstreet at one in the morning. Mara went to find the truth Vera refused to look at.

She sets the letter down very carefully, beside the empty cups. Then she opens the notebook and turns the pages.

Her father's handwriting. Neat, slanted, careful.

DANIEL (V.O.)
Shiohama. Third visit. The residents say men came in the spring with flowers, and then in the summer with iron bars. The fire began in two places at once. Fires don't do that.

She turns pages. The handwriting grows faster.

DANIEL (V.O.) (CONT'D)
The claim will be paid. Everyone wants it paid. The company, the police, the man who owns the land now. Kurose. Always Kurose.

Pages.

DANIEL (V.O.) (CONT'D)
The police have given me a young detective who speaks English. They call him Jack. He's bright. He believes me. We ate noodles at Kaneko's and I told him everything and he wrote it all down.

Vera stops. Reads that line again.

Her hand goes to her mouth.

She turns the page. The line we didn't see Jack read, underlined twice.

DANIEL (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 Today Jack signed the report.
 Accidental fire. I don't blame him.
 He is twenty-eight years old and
 they own his whole life. But I
 thought, of all of them, he would
 stand with me.

Vera stares at the page.

DANIEL (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 I'll go on alone. I've done it
 before.

The last pages. The handwriting is almost unrecognisable now.

DANIEL (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 They followed me home again
 tonight. The girls were asleep. I
 stood at the door a long time.
 (beat)
 If something happens to me, it will
 not be what they say. Tell Vera.
 When she is old enough. Tell her it
 will not be what they say.

Vera closes the notebook.

For twenty years she believed her father chose to leave her.

She sits in the grey light, holding the notebook against her
 chest, the way she held the lighter.

She has been given back her father and taken Jack away in the
 same hour. She doesn't know which to feel first.

80

INT. POLICE STATION, DETECTIVES' ROOM - DAY

80

Rows of cluttered desks. Phones. The radio playing low
 somewhere. On the wall, the clock that runs a minute fast.

Ishida sits at his desk writing a report in careful longhand.

Jack walks the length of the room. Detectives look up and
 then look away. He hasn't shaved. There is still dried blood
 in the creases of his knuckles.

He stops at Ishida's desk. Ishida doesn't look up.

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 Nine o'clock. A grey car. Your
 driver.

Ishida finishes his sentence. Puts down the pen.

JACK (CONT'D)
(in Japanese)
Only you knew.

A long pause.

ISHIDA
(in Japanese)
You told me yourself, Jack.
(beat)
You always tell the wrong person.

Jack's hands close at his sides. The room has gone quiet around them.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Twenty years ago. Daniel. Was that you?

ISHIDA
(in Japanese)
I have never killed anyone in my life.
(beat)
I only ever told people where to find them.

Jack looks at him for a long time. Everyone in the room is waiting for him to hit Ishida.

He doesn't.

ISHIDA (CONT'D)
(in Japanese)
Where is it? Sakai's thing.

Jack turns and walks away down the long room, past the desks, past the clock.

Ishida watches him go. For the first time, he looks afraid.

81 INT. SMALL BAR, KANDA - DAY

81

The bar in daylight. Chairs on the tables. Okada behind the counter.

He sees Jack's face and his hands, and he doesn't ask. He opens the cash drawer, lifts out the tray, and hands Jack the cassette.

Jack holds it.

OKADA
(in Japanese)
The girl?

Jack can't answer.

Okada closes his eyes. Then he pours two small glasses and puts one in front of Jack. They drink together, without a toast.

82 INT. TOTO SHIMBUN NEWSROOM - DAY

82

An old newspaper office. Stacks of paper. Desks jammed together. Televisions on the walls showing three different channels. Nobody under fifty looks up from a screen.

In a glass-walled office at the back: HARADA (50s), the editor, grey-haired, sleeves rolled. On her desk, a framed photo of the JOURNALIST from the bar, laughing at some office party.

On the desk between them: an old cassette player, borrowed from somewhere, and the tape.

Harada presses PLAY.

Hiss. Then two men's voices, twenty years younger. Sakai's rough. The other one smooth, patient, faintly bored.

SAKAI (V.O.)
(in Japanese; recorded)
There are still people in the building. Old people. They won't sign.

KUROSE (V.O.)
(in Japanese; recorded)
The building must be empty by the end of the month.

SAKAI (V.O.)
(in Japanese; recorded)
And if it isn't?

KUROSE (V.O.)
 (in Japanese; recorded)
 Then it will be empty in a
 different way.
 (beat)
 Don't make me say it more clearly,
 Sakai. I don't like to repeat
 myself.

Harada stops the tape. The newsroom noise outside the glass
 seems very far away.

HARADA
 (in Japanese)
 That's Kurose.

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 That's Kurose.

HARADA
 (in Japanese)
 A voice on a twenty-year-old tape.
 His lawyers will say it's a fake.
 They'll say Sakai was a gangster
 with a grudge.

JACK
 (in Japanese)
 Then you'll need a witness.

She looks at him.

JACK (CONT'D)
 (in Japanese)
 Twenty years ago I was a police
 detective. An American insurance
 investigator named Daniel Voss
 proved the Shiohama fire was arson.
 I believed him. I was ordered to
 close the case, and I signed a
 report saying the fire was an
 accident.
 (beat)
 Weeks later he was found dead. I
 didn't ask any questions.

HARADA
 (in Japanese)
 You understand what you're saying.
 You'll be named. Your part too.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Start with my part.

Harada looks at him for a long moment. Then she looks at the photograph of her dead reporter on the desk. She takes a notebook from her drawer and opens it to a clean page.

HARADA
(in Japanese)
From the beginning.

Jack begins to talk. We don't hear it. We watch him through the glass wall of her office, among the busy desks and flickering televisions: a man, for the first time in twenty years, not silent.

83 INT. CHAIRMAN'S OFFICE, KUROSE DEVELOPMENT - DAY

83

The fortieth floor. Rain on the glass. Tokyo grey and endless below.

Vera sits in a leather chair in front of Kurose's desk. She wears a plain dark coat. Her father's notebook is on her lap, her hands flat on its cover.

Kurose sits across from her. Courteous. Curious. He pours her tea himself.

KUROSE
When my secretary said the daughter
of Daniel Voss wanted to see me, I
didn't believe her.

His English is perfect. Old-fashioned.

KUROSE (CONT'D)
You have his eyes. He looked at
people the same way. As if he
expected them to tell the truth.

VERA
Did you?

KUROSE
To him? I don't remember.
(beat)
Your father was a good man, Miss
Voss. I mean that sincerely. There
are not many.
(beat)
Good men are very expensive.

Vera doesn't touch the tea.

KUROSE (CONT'D)
What is it you want? Money is
vulgar. But it is also useful. For
a young woman alone, in a foreign
city.

VERA
I wanted to see your face.

KUROSE
And?

VERA
It's just a face.

For the first time, something flickers in him. Not fear.
Irritation, perhaps, at being looked at like that.

Vera stands. She holds up the notebook. Not threatening. Just
showing it to him.

VERA (CONT'D)
My father kept notes. He wrote your
name on every page.
(beat)
And now I know.

She walks to the door. Stops beside the glass case with the
model of the redevelopment inside. She looks down at it: the
little white towers, the little plaza, the fountain where the
Hive is.

VERA (CONT'D)
It's very clean.

She goes.

Kurose sits still for a moment. Then he presses a button on
his desk phone.

KUROSE
(in Japanese; into phone)
Follow her.

84 INT. THE HIVE, NOODLE SHOP STOREROOM - NIGHT

84

The bulb. The flour sacks. The futon, folded now.

Jack sits on the floor against the wall. He has been hiding
here since the newspaper; he can't go home. His face is grey
with exhaustion.

The curtain opens. Kaneko.

KANEKO
(in Japanese)
Someone for you.

She stands aside.

Vera.

Jack gets to his feet. Neither of them moves toward the other.

VERA
She asked me to come. Kaneko. She
said I should see where Mara was.

She looks around the tiny room. The bare bulb. The flour sacks. And on the wall, taped up with rice-paper tape, pages from Mara's sketchbook: drawings of the noodle counter, but from the inside now. From behind the curtain. The back of a head on the third stool.

Vera walks to the wall. Looks at the drawing for a long time.

VERA (CONT'D)
That's me.

JACK
She drew it after you left.

VERA
She was here. The day I came.

JACK
Three feet away.

Vera touches the paper with one finger.

VERA
And you told her not to come out.

JACK
She told herself.
(beat)
She was protecting you. So was I.
We were both wrong.

VERA
I read his notebook.

JACK
I know.

VERA
He didn't blame you.

JACK
I know.

VERA
I don't know if I'm as good as he
was.

JACK
I'm not asking you to be.

Silence. A train passes overhead. The bulb swings.

And under the train, so quietly it's almost part of it: in the passage outside, a man's voice, murmuring into his sleeve.

MASKED MAN (O.S.)
(in Japanese)
Position.

Jack's head snaps round. Vera sees his face and understands. The bulb goes on swinging.

85 INT. THE HIVE, PASSAGES - CONTINUOUS 85

Four masked men move through the narrow corridors in single file, weapons up. The passages are too narrow for anything else.

Doors that stood open close softly, one after another, as they pass. The Hive is watching them.

86 INT. KANEKO'S NOODLE COUNTER - CONTINUOUS 86

Kaneko pulls the shutter down with a crash. She turns off the fluorescent tube.

KANEKO
(in Japanese; to Jack)
Up. Through the back. The stairs by the dentist. All the way to the roof.

JACK
(in Japanese)
Come with us.

KANEKO
 (in Japanese)
 I have lived here fifty years. They
 can come and find me.

She pushes them toward the back.

87 INT. THE HIVE, RADIO REPAIR SHOP - CONTINUOUS 87

The RADIO REPAIRMAN looks up from his bench at the sound of boots in the corridor. He looks at the old fuse box on his wall.

He reaches up and pulls the main switch.

88 INT. THE HIVE, PASSAGES - CONTINUOUS 88

DARK.

Every bulb in the building goes out at once.

The masked men stop. Flashlights snap on, tight white beams in the narrow corridors, catching dripping pipes, closed doors, laundry, faces at windows that vanish the moment the light touches them.

The Hive knows its own dark. The men don't.

89 INT. THE HIVE, STAIRWELL - CONTINUOUS 89

Pitch black. Vera and Jack climbing a narrow concrete stair by touch. Her hand on the wall. His hand finding hers in the dark.

She lets him.

Below them, a flashlight beam sweeps the bottom of the stairwell. They freeze.

Somewhere a DOG starts barking. Then a baby cries. Then a radio, somewhere, turned up very loud: an old ballad. The one from the neighbour's wall.

Then another radio. Then a television. Then someone banging a pot with a spoon.

The whole building starts to make noise, on purpose, all at once. The flashlight swings away, confused.

Jack and Vera climb.

90 EXT. THE HIVE, ROOFTOP - CONTINUOUS 90

The flat roof of the Hive's low rear wing, four storeys up, the dark bulk of the tower rising behind it.

Rain. Wind. Water tanks, television aerials, laundry poles, pigeon cages. The whole forest of the Hive's roof, and beyond it, Tokyo in every direction, lit and indifferent.

At the edge, very close, the elevated railway: a narrow maintenance walkway running beside the tracks, separated from the roof by a gap of a metre and a low fence.

Jack helps Vera over the gap. She has one hand in his. She jumps. He follows.

91 EXT. RAILWAY MAINTENANCE WALKWAY - CONTINUOUS 91

A narrow steel walkway beside the tracks. Behind them, a door bangs open on the Hive's roof. Flashlight beams sweep the aerials and water tanks.

And ahead, the rails begin to sing. A light grows at the far end of the viaduct.

A train.

Jack pulls Vera flat against the fence at the edge of the walkway. There is nowhere else to go.

The train arrives. A roaring wall of noise and wind and lit windows, a metre from their faces, strobing across them. Passengers inside reading, sleeping, looking at their phones. None of them see.

Vera and Jack are pressed together against the fence, faces inches apart, rain and train-light washing over them.

She doesn't pull away this time.

On the Hive's roof, the flashlight beams search the tracks. The train stands between them and the walkway, carriage after carriage.

When the last carriage passes, the walkway is empty.

92 EXT. STREET BELOW THE VIADUCT - MOMENTS LATER 92

Vera and Jack come down a steel maintenance ladder into an empty street. Soaked. Breathing hard.

Behind them, the Hive: every window lit again now, every radio playing, every resident awake. In the distance, sirens.

Vera steps away from him. Just one step. Enough.

They look at each other in the rain. There is too much to say, and none of it can be said tonight.

VERA
Is Kaneko --

JACK
The Hive looks after its own.

She nods. She looks up at the building full of light.

VERA
Mara was safe here. Until us.

He has no answer to that. She doesn't need one.

93 EXT. POLICE STATION - NIGHT 93

Rain. Ishida comes down the front steps without an umbrella.

At the kerb, a black sedan. Engine running. Wipers beating slowly.

He stops. He knows this car.

A long moment. Then the rear door opens from inside.

94 INT. BLACK SEDAN, BACK SEAT - CONTINUOUS 94

Warm amber light. Leather. The rain is suddenly very far away.

Kurose sits in the back, impeccable, a small steel flask in his hands. He does not look at Ishida. He pours tea into the flask's cup.

KUROSE
(in Japanese)
Get in, Ishida. You'll catch cold.

Ishida gets in. The door closes. The sound of the rain becomes a soft drumming on the roof.

The car pulls away.

Kurose offers him the cup. Ishida looks at it.

KUROSE (CONT'D)
 (in Japanese)
 It's only tea.

Ishida takes it. Doesn't drink.

ISHIDA
 (in Japanese)
 I did everything you asked. For
 twenty years.

KUROSE
 (in Japanese)
 Yes. You were always very careful.
 (beat)
 That's why I trusted you. And
 that's why you understand.

Ishida looks out of the window. Tokyo slides past in the rain: a lit vending machine, a closed noodle shop, an elevated train full of sleeping strangers.

ISHIDA
 (in Japanese)
 Where are we going?

Kurose doesn't answer. He simply looks ahead, as if the question was impolite.

Ishida nods, slowly. He understands.

He lifts the cup, and drinks the tea.

95 EXT. TOKYO STREET - CONTINUOUS

95

The black car recedes down a long wet road, its taillights smearing red, exactly like the car in the first scene of the film.

It turns a corner. Gone.

96 INT. POLICE STATION, DETECTIVES' ROOM - MORNING

96

Grey daylight. A cardboard box on Ishida's desk. A young detective is clearing it.

He opens the bottom drawer. Empty.

On the wall, the clock still runs a minute fast.

97 EXT. THE HIVE - MORNING

97

Rain.

In front of the Hive, a white ceremonial tent. Rows of folding chairs. A podium. Officials in dark suits. A giant banner of the computer rendering: glass towers, the little plaza, the fountain. TOMORROW'S TOKYO. A silver shovel on a stand, tied with a red-and-white ribbon, waiting for the ground-breaking.

Across the street, a small electronics shop. In its window, a row of televisions, old CRTs and new flat screens side by side, all showing the same morning news: a photograph of Kurose, and a front page of the Toto Shimbun held up to the camera.

People on the pavement slow down to watch. Then stop.

Among them, beside Kaneko, under a plain umbrella: Vera.

A black car pulls up at the tent. An AIDE hurries round with a large umbrella and opens the rear door.

Kurose steps out. Immaculate. He buttons his jacket. He turns toward the podium.

Four men in plain dark suits are standing between him and it. PROSECUTORS. One of them holds up an identification card and says something we can't hear.

Kurose looks at them. For a moment, nothing happens at all.

Then the lead prosecutor gestures toward a plain grey car at the kerb.

The aide steps forward with the umbrella. The prosecutor shakes his head, very slightly.

The aide lowers it.

Kurose walks from the tent to the grey car. Twenty metres. In the rain. No umbrella.

The rain soaks his silver hair flat. It darkens the shoulders of his beautiful suit. By the time he reaches the car, he looks like what he is: an old man.

Cameras flash. The CRTs in the shop window show the same moment, a second behind, over and over.

Vera watches the whole twenty metres. She does not look away.

Kaneko takes Vera's hand.

Further down the street, alone, collar up: Jack. Watching too.

Vera sees him. He sees her.

Across the street, through the rain and the camera flashes, neither of them moves.

The grey car pulls away. Behind it, the silver shovel stands on its stand, untouched, its ribbon going dark in the rain.

98

EXT. ROOFTOP OF JACK'S BUILDING - DAY

98

Days later. The rain has stopped for the first time in the film. The sky is pale and washed and enormous.

A small flat roof: laundry poles, a water tank, a single potted plant someone has kept alive. Below, the elevated railway, and the trains going past at eye level.

Jack stands at the railing. He hears the door behind him.

Vera. In a plain coat. Her hair dry.

She comes to stand beside him at the railing. Not close. Not far.

VERA

Harada says the prosecutors want you to testify.

JACK

Yes.

VERA

And your licence?

JACK

Gone.

(beat)

It should have gone twenty years ago.

A train passes below. They watch it.

Jack takes something from his pocket. Holds it out on his open palm.

The red bird clip.

JACK (CONT'D)

This is yours.

Vera looks at it. She takes it.

JACK (CONT'D)
She said your father gave it to
her. She said you only claim it was
yours.

Vera laughs. It comes out broken.

VERA
Liar. It was mine.

She closes her hand around it.

Jack looks at the trains. It is the hardest thing he will
ever say, and he says it simply.

JACK
At the end, she asked me to tell
you something.

Vera goes very still.

JACK (CONT'D)
She said to tell you she was sorry.

Vera stares at him.

And then she understands. Not the words. What they mean. The
fight. The last cruel things she said at the door. The flight
home. Everything she has carried since the first scene.

Mara wasn't angry. Mara had forgiven her the whole time.

Vera turns away to the railing. Her shoulders shake. Jack
doesn't touch her. He stands beside her while she cries, the
way he knelt beside her in the rain. Close enough. Not
closer.

When she can speak:

VERA
You could have told me that in the
rain.

JACK
I couldn't say anything in the
rain.

VERA
No.
(beat)
Neither could I.

A train. They watch it pass.

VERA (CONT'D)
I don't know what we are.

JACK
Neither do I.

VERA
I still have your lighter.

JACK
I know.

She takes it from her coat pocket. Looks at it. Opens it.
Closes it.

She doesn't give it back. She puts it away again.

VERA
Kaneko's opening a new place. Near
the station, under the arches.
She's taking the sign. And the
stools.

(beat)
She says the third one's still
mine.

She walks to the rooftop door. Stops. Doesn't look back.

VERA (CONT'D)
She says she opens at six.

She goes.

Jack stands alone at the railing. A train passes, its windows
full of people. For a moment, in one of the windows, the
reflection of his own face.

99 EXT. THE HIVE - DAY

99

Weeks later.

The Hive is coming down.

Excavators bite into the walls with long steel jaws. Concrete
falls in slow grey curtains. Dust hangs in the air.

The building has been cut open like the illustrated
cross-sections in an old book. Rooms stand exposed to the
sky, stacked one above another: a wall of flowered wallpaper,
a calendar still pinned beside a window, a mirror, a child's
height marks pencilled on a doorframe.

The camera tracks slowly sideways along the ruined face of the building, as it tracked along the lit windows of the living one. Empty room after empty room. We remember who lived in each.

At the barrier on the street, a small crowd watches. The radio repairman. The family. The girl with the violin case.

Kaneko stands among them, holding the old noodle-shop sign against her chest, wrapped in a blanket.

100 INT. KANEKO'S NEW COUNTER - NIGHT

100

A tiny place in a brick railway arch near the station. Six new stools, the same height as the old ones. Steam. One warm bulb. A small radio on the shelf, playing low.

Above the counter, the old hand-painted sign. Faded. Unmistakable.

Kaneko works the pot with long chopsticks.

Vera sits on the third stool. A bowl in front of her. The red bird clip in her hair.

A train passes overhead. The bulb trembles. The steam shivers. Nobody looks up.

On the radio, the old ballad begins. The one from the neighbour's wall.

Vera eats.

Behind her, the door opens.

Cool blue street light spills across the floor. And into it, a long shadow falls: a man in a coat, standing in the doorway, his shadow stretching all the way across the floor to the foot of her stool.

Vera sees the shadow. She stops eating.

She doesn't turn.

Kaneko looks up at the door. Then at Vera. Then, without a word, she takes down a second bowl and sets it on the counter in front of the fourth stool.

Vera looks at the second bowl.

HOLD on the back of her head, the red clip, the steam, the shadow on the floor.

She doesn't turn.

CUT TO BLACK.

Over black: a train passing. Rain beginning again, softly.

THE END